was Lieutenant John Haughton, who had escaped from Charikar with Eldred Pottinger, and who now succeeded in finding, and in many cases liberating from slavery, no fewer than 165 of his Gurkhas whom he managed to track down in the fields, streets and slave markets of Kabul. In all, some 2,000 sepoys and camp followers were found to have survived. They were collected together with two officers appointed to provide for them and give them access to medical treatment, including, in some cases, amputations.[88]

Parties also began to be sent out to begin digging graves for the thousands of British and Indian cadavers still lying scattered around the city, 'calling out to us to avenge them', as Mohan Lal put it.[89] Soon the troops were pressing Pollock to make some public demonstration to punish the people of Kabul. Pollock needed little encouragement.

On his defeat, Akbar Khan had fled northwards to Khulm and was now well out of reach, but Naib Aminullah Khan Logari and his tribesmen along with the Ghazis of Parwan had decided to fortify themselves in the pleasure resort of Istalif, just thirty-five miles north of Kabul.

Istalif was always renowned as one of the most beautiful places in Afghanistan – the Emperor Babur fell in love with it in the sixteenth century and used to hold wine parties in his summer house and rose garden there; 300 years later Burnes had come here to relax and get away from the diplomatic complexities of Kabul amid the plane and walnut trees, the mountain streams full of fish and 'the richest orchards and vineyards'. It was here that Pollock decided to concentrate his revenge.

As they marched out of Kabul through the vineyards of the Shomali Plain, Pollock's troops were also enchanted by the 'clear streams and green fields' around the hilltown which had charmed so many travellers before them. But it did not stop them laying waste to the place. The town was surrounded, attacked and then systematically pillaged. When 500 enslaved sepoys were found chained in pitiful conditions in the basements, the Afghan wounded were collected in heaps and 'the sepoys set fire to the cotton clothing of their victims', burning them alive. The women of Istalif were then divided among the troops by throws of the dice.[90]

Neville Chamberlain's cavalry were part of the rearguard. By the time he got to Istalif, the scene, he wrote, was 'beyond description . . . Tents,